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TO : **ALL EMPLOYEES**

FROM : Davao Baking Center

DATE : July 20, 2023

SUBJECT: FOOD SAFETY & HYGIENE

(DBC Internal Policies & Procedures 2023 - 03)

An Introduction to Food Hygiene

This guide walks you through what food hygiene is, its difference from food safety, its importance, types, and risks of not practicing it.

What is Food Hygiene?

As an important part of food safety and ensuring the health and well-being of consumers, food hygiene is the practice of handling, preparing, and storing food in a way that prevents food-borne illnesses. Also, it's a set of guidelines designed to keep food safe from contamination and spoilage.

Everyone involved in the food industry must understand and practice food hygiene and adhere to strict food safety regulations. The practice of food hygiene involves the use of proper sanitation and cleaning practices, as well as the use of Personal Protective Equipment (PPE).

Who is Responsible for It?

Everyone in the food chain has a responsibility to ensure that food is safe and free from contamination. This includes food producers, processors, distributors, retailers, caterers, and consumers.

Food hygiene is especially important for those who work in the food industry, such as premix controllers, bakers, cake decorators, cooks (filling), packing associates, delivery personnel, and other food handlers. They must be aware of the risks associated with food contamination and take steps to prevent it. This practice is also important for those who work in food-related businesses, such as DBC commissary, bread production (outlets), and store operations. These businesses must ensure that their employees are properly trained in food safety and hygiene practices and that their premises are kept clean and free from hazards. They must also ensure that their food is stored and handled correctly to avoid contamination.

What is the Difference Between Food Hygiene and Food Safety?

Food safety refers to a wide range of practices and aspects that food businesses apply as part of their Food Safety Management System (FSMS). One aspect of it is food hygiene, which focuses on implementing food safety measures while maintaining cleanliness and orderliness in the workplace as workers deal with food products.

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Why is Food Hygiene Important?

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) estimates that 1.35 million illnesses, 26,500 hospitalizations, and 420 deaths in the United States yearly are caused by Salmonella.

Food Hygiene and Sanitation Practices

Good hygiene and sanitation practices are essential in the food industry to ensure that food is safe for consumption. Proper sanitation practices help to prevent foodborne illnesses, which can be caused by a variety of factors, including improper storage, contamination from animals or pests, and inadequate preparation.

The following are some common hygiene and sanitation practices used in the food industry:

1. **Cleaning**: All surfaces and equipment used in the preparation of food should be cleaned regularly with hot water and detergent. This helps to remove dirt, grease, bacteria, and other contaminants that could cause food-borne illness.

2. **Sanitizing**: After cleaning, surfaces and equipment should be sanitized with an approved sanitizing agent such as chlorine or Quaternary ammonium compounds (QUATs). This helps to reduce the number of bacteria on surfaces that could potentially contaminate food.

3. **Personal Hygiene**: All employees working in the food industry should practice good personal hygiene by washing their hands often with soap and water before handling any food items or equipment.

4. **Separation:** Raw foods such as meat, poultry, fish, eggs, fruits, and vegetables should be kept separate from cooked foods to avoid cross-contamination. Different types of raw foods should also be kept separate from each other to prevent cross-contamination between different types of raw foods.

5. **Temperature Control**: Foods must be stored at appropriate temperatures to prevent the growth of bacteria that can cause foodborne illness. Refrigerated items should be stored at 40 degrees Fahrenheit or below while frozen items should be stored at 0 degrees Fahrenheit or below. Hot foods should be held at 140 degrees Fahrenheit or above until served or cooled quickly to 40 degrees Fahrenheit or below before being refrigerated for storage.

6. **Pest Control**: The presence of pests such as rodents and insects can pose a serious health hazard if they come into contact with food products or equipment used in the preparation of those products. To prevent this from happening businesses need to have an effective pest control program in place that includes regular inspections for signs of infestation as well as regular treatments by a professional pest control company if necessary.

Mitigate the Risk of Food-borne Illnesses

Food handlers who practice proper food hygiene can reduce the risk of foodborne illnesses, which can be caused by bacteria, viruses, and parasites. Also, safe and hygienic preparation of food is key to reducing the risk of food spoilage and lessening food waste.

Protect Business Reputation

Food businesses can demonstrate to their customers that they are taking the necessary steps to ensure the safety of their food. This can foster and maintain customer trust and loyalty, leading to increased sales and profits.

Reduce Environmental Impact

Food hygiene also plays a key role in helping businesses become eco-friendly in various ways. This includes reducing the amount of food waste that is produced, as well as the amount of energy and water used in the preparation and production of food.

Types

Several different types of food hygiene must be followed to ensure the safety of food. Some of these include the following:

Personal Hygiene

This includes washing hands before and after handling food, wearing clean clothes and hairnets, and avoiding contact with food if you have any open wounds or cuts. It's also important to keep food preparation areas clean and free from pests.

Food Storage

This type involves storing food at the correct temperature, using separate containers for raw and cooked food, and ensuring that food is not left out of the refrigerator for too long. It is also essential to *label food with the date* it was prepared and discard any food that has been left out for too long.

Food Preparation Hygiene

This includes *washing* all fruits and vegetables before use, cooking food to the correct temperature, and avoiding cross-contamination between raw and cooked food. It is also important to use clean utensils and surfaces when preparing food.

Risks of Not Practicing Food Hygiene

Food Contamination and Poisoning

Not following proper food hygiene practices can lead to food contamination. This can cause food poisoning, food-borne illnesses such as Salmonella and E. coli infections, and a range of symptoms, from mild stomach upset to severe dehydration and even death.

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Quick Food Spoilage

Not following food hygiene practices can also lead to the growth of bacteria and other microorganisms in food. This can cause food to spoil quickly, leading to food waste and financial losses.

Spread of Pests

Pests such as rodents and insects can contaminate food and spread diseases, as well as cause damage to food storage areas and equipment. In addition, pests can also spread allergens, which can cause serious health problems.

Should you have any clarifications, please contact the undersigned. Thank you and God bless.

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